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PowerPoint Transcript

Slide One:

Hello everyone, welcome to Old Town Historical Society's staff training on patron relations. Today we're going to talk about something that is at the heart of what we do: connecting with the people who walk through our doors. When I think about why I love working in archives, it's not just about the fascinating materials that we get to work with every day; it's about those moments when you see someone's face light up because they found exactly what they were looking for, or maybe something they never expected to discover.

Every single person who comes to us has a story. Maybe they're a graduate student, panicking about their thesis deadline, or a genealogist hoping to learn more about their great-grandmother, or perhaps a local historian working on a new project. They all need our help, and we are often the difference between a successful research experience and a frustrating dead end.

Essentially, we serve as bridges between the past and the present, to help researchers, students, and community members connect with historical materials that tell the story of our shared heritage. And honestly, the quality of our patron interactions directly impacts not only individual research experiences but also the reputation and mission of our historical society. When we excel in patron relations, we foster a love of history, we support academic achievement, and strengthen our community's connections to cultural heritage.

Slide Two:

You may be asking why are patron relations so important. Well, every person who walks through our doors brings unique research needs, and these needs vary in levels of archival experience and comfort levels with technology.

Our job is to meet them where they are and guide them successfully through their research journey. This requires a combination of technical knowledge, interpersonal skills, and a genuine commitment to service excellence. Today we're going to dive into key areas that will help you become even better at what you do. We'll talk about helping patrons navigate our collections, getting comfortable with technology, making sure everyone feels welcome and can access our materials, and how to just generally be awesome at customer service.

Slide Three:

When we first meet with researchers, it is important to sit down and really understand what they're looking for. We want to learn about their research goals and then help them figure out which of our collections might be most useful. Walking them through the relevant finding aids together makes this process run a lot smoother. Our approach to orienting new visitors works best when we balance structure with flexibility. We start by having a genuine conversation about what they're researching and what they hope to accomplish. From there, we can point them toward the materials in our collections that might be helpful. We will go through the finding aids together and show them how to read and understand the organizational structure, so that they can navigate it on their own later. We also make sure to explain how our material retrieval system works and give them a tour of the research space. This includes going over our policies and procedures. But we try to do this in a way that feels welcoming, rather than overwhelming. The goal is to help researchers feel confident and comfortable using our resources.

Slide Four:

We all know this work isn't always easy. Some days you will have patrons who know exactly what they want and just need a little guidance. Other days, you will spend an hour with someone who says they want ”anything about the Civil War,” and you slowly begin to realize that they are actually looking for information about their ancestor’s military pension. It's all part of the detective work that makes this job interesting. The thing is, most people have no idea how archives work. They come in, expecting it to be like Google, where you type in a search term and get instant results. But we know it is more like being at an archaeological dig where you have to understand the layers and context to eventually find the treasure. When you first visited an archive, you might have noticed things felt different from your local library. While libraries organize books by subject, archives keep materials in the order they were originally created or received. We call this provenance, and it’s basically like preserving the natural flow of how documents lived in their original setting. This can throw people off at first, especially if they are used to browsing library shelves, where all the books about World War Two are grouped together. In an archive, those World War Two documents might be scattered across different collections based on who originally created them.

When helping visitors navigate the system, archivists have learned a few things that work really well. Instead of jumping straight to suggesting collections, we start with open-ended questions to really understand what the individual is researching and why. We take time to explain how archives differ from libraries, so the patron knows what to expect. And finding aids can look intimidating, so we walk them through how to effectively read them.

We should also be upfront about timing. Pulling materials from storage can take a while, so we need to help the patron plan accordingly. And when their first-choice collection doesn't pan out, we are ready with suggestions for other materials that might work just as well for their research. The goal is to help the patron become confident navigating a system that might seem backward at first, but actually preserves the authentic context of historical materials.

Slide Five:

Okay, so let's talk about finding aids. I know they can seem intimidating, even to us sometimes. But here's the thing: finding aids are basically the road map, or GPS system, for our collections, and we need to be really good tour guides. Think about it this way: a finding aid is like a family tree for documents. At the top you've got the big picture- what's in this collection, who created it, and why it matters. Then you drill down through the branches, and the series descriptions are like the main family groups…correspondence over here, photographs over there, financial records in a totally different branch.

When someone walks in and says they are researching labor unions in the 1940s, we don't just point them to a box. We sit down with them and walk through the finding aid together. "See this series on 'Strike Correspondence '? That might have what you need. But also check out the photograph series. There might be pictures from the picket lines that could really bring your research to life."

The container lists are where things get specific. "Box 3, Folder 12 might contain what you need, but they will never find it without understanding the bigger picture first. And here is something I have learned: always explain that the organization reflects how the materials were originally kept. It's not random, and it is not organized by subject, like library books. But there is a story in how things were filed, and that story matters.

One more thing: finding aids follow standards like DACS, which stands for Describing Archives, a Content Standard. This isn't just bureaucratic stuff. It means that once someone learns how to read our finding aids, they can navigate any archives, anywhere. We are actually teaching them a life skill.

Slide Six:

Technology has become a cornerstone of how we work in modern archives. To help our visitors effectively, we need to master our digital catalog systems by learning how to search using Boolean operators, target specific fields, and apply the right filters. We also need to spend time getting comfortable with databases, hopping between records, bookmarking

our searches, and exploring our vast digital collections. We can't help our patrons if we're not familiar with our systems.

Slide Seven:

When patrons visit us, they come with all kinds of technology needs.

Some people need a hand with computer basics, like figuring out where their files went, getting something to print properly, or saving their work. Others want help using our digital cameras and scanners to capture copies of historical documents and materials. We're constantly helping people with online research, showing them how to search databases and guiding them through our digital collections. And yes, we also end up being the go-to people when the equipment decides to act up.

Troubleshooting has definitely become a part of our everyday routine. An archivist wears many hats.

Slide Eight:

This is where things get a bit technical, but stay with me because patrons ask about this stuff all the time:

“Why isn't this online?” “Can you just email me a copy?” “Why does this look so fuzzy?”

Digital preservation is complicated because we're not just making copies; we're making copies that need to last decades, or maybe even centuries. Think about it: how many computer files do you have from ten years ago that you cannot open anymore? Now imagine trying to keep something accessible for one hundred years. We have to think about file formats. JPEG may be fine for your vacation photos, but for preservation, we need TIFF files that won't degrade over time. PDF is great for sharing, but for long-term storage, we need PDF/A, that meets specific standards. These decisions affect what we can provide to our patrons and how quickly we can provide it.

Then there's the whole issue of storage and backup. You know the 3-2-1 rule, right? Three copies of everything, on two different types of media, with one stored offsite. It sounds simple enough, but when you're dealing with terabytes of data, it gets expensive and complicated pretty fast. Migration is ongoing work. We're constantly moving files from older systems to newer ones, making sure that nothing gets lost in translation. It's like renovating a house while people are still living in it.

And then, of course, the issue of copyright. Just because we own the physical item doesn’t mean we can put it online. We might own a diary from 1985, but the person who wrote it, or

their family member, still owns the copyright. These legal issues explain why some things just can't be digitized for public access, no matter how much someone wants them to be.

Slide Nine:

Let’s be real about technology for a minute. Some of you love it, some of you tolerate it, and some of you probably wish we could go back to card catalogs. But our patrons need our help with technology, so we have to get comfortable with it. The good news is, you don't need to be a computer wizard; you just need to know the basics well enough to help someone who knows even less than you do. I always tell the staff, ”if you can help your mom figure out her smartphone, you can help a patron with our catalog system.”

But here’s what’s really important for technology training: hands-on practice, lots of it. Don't just read about how the database works; actually use it. Try searching for weird things, break it up a little, and figure out what happens when the system doesn't cooperate, because I guarantee you, that's when the patron will be standing right there waiting for help.

Quick reference guides are your best friend. I'm talking about simple one-page cheat sheets that you can grab when you're helping someone and your mind goes blank. We’ve all been there; a patron asks how to print something and suddenly you forget every computer skill you have ever learned. Having that guide right there saves the day. And when technology fails, and it will, have a backup plan. Know who to call, know what alternative to offer, and know how to keep the patron from getting frustrated while we figure it all out.

The thing about technology and archives is that it's constantly changing; what we used five year ago is already outdated. So implementing technology training isn't a one-and-done thing. We need regular check-ins, updates when the system changes, and honest conversations about what's working and what isn't.

Slide Ten:

Accessibility isn't just about ramps and elevators, although those are important. It's about creating an environment where everyone can succeed, regardless of their physical abilities, cultural background, or comfort level with technology.

Slide Eleven:

Physical accessibility is the obvious starting point. We need to ensure that people using wheelchairs can access the materials they are in search of, that our tables can accommodate their various needs, and that our signage is clear and easy to read. But we also need to think about less obvious things: is the lighting adequate for someone with low

vision, or are our chairs comfortable enough for someone who might spend several hours researching?

Slide Twelve:

Digital accessibility is becoming more important as more of our resources move online. Screen readers need to be able to navigate our websites, videos need captions, and images need descriptive text. This isn't just nice to have; it's essential for equal access.

Slide Thirteen:

Creating a truly inclusive service means putting people first in everything that we do. This starts with how we talk. So, for example, using person-first language that recognizes someone as a whole person rather than defining them by a disability or condition. So instead of saying “the blind patron,” we say “the patron who is blind.” It’s a small shift that makes a big difference in how people feel seen and respected. We’ve also learned that assuming what someone needs can actually be more harmful than helpful. That’s why we always ask before jumping in to assist. Someone using a wheelchair might not need help opening a door. And someone with a visual impairment might prefer to navigate independently.

When we ask questions like, "Would you like me to describe the layout of the reading room?" or "How can I best help you access these materials?" We're respecting their independence and expertise about their own needs.

Assistive devices are extensions of someone’s independence, so we treat them with the same respect that we would show anyone’s personal belongings. We never move someone’s cane, lean on their wheelchair, or touch their service animal without permission. Personal space matters, too. We maintain appropriate distance and always ask before providing physical guidance.

Communication looks different for everyone. Some people prefer written instructions, others benefit from verbal explanations, and some do best with visual demonstrations, so we try to offer multiple ways to share information and stay flexible. If someone uses sign language and we don’t, we will grab a paper and pen, use our phone to type, or find other creative ways to connect with the patron.

Time pressures can turn what should be a helpful interaction into a stressful one. When someone needs extra time to process information, ask questions, or navigate our space, we have to build that into our service. Rushing never helps anyone, and patience often makes the difference between someone feeling welcomed or excluded.

Perhaps most importantly, we work to create environments where people feel comfortable being themselves. This means checking our assumptions at the door, avoiding judgment about how someone communicates or moves through the world, and recognizing that everyone's research needs and questions are valid. When people feel genuinely welcomed, rather than merely tolerated, they're more likely to return and make full use of our resources.

Slide Fourteen:

Cultural sensitivity requires us to think about whose stories are told in our collections, and whose might be missing. When someone from an underrepresented community comes in looking for materials, we need to be honest about the gaps in our collections while also helping them find what is available. We may need to suggest other repositories or sources they hadn't considered. Inclusivity is about ensuring everyone feels like they belong here. This means using welcoming language, avoiding slang words and not making assumptions about what the people know. Cultural sensitivity isn't just a checkbox that needs to be ticked; It really does touch everything that we do here, and it has become increasingly important. Every person who walks through our doors brings their own history, their own family story, and their own relationship to the past we're helping them explore.

A few years ago, a Native American researcher came in looking for materials on her tribal history. As we went through the documents, it became clear that almost everything we had was written by government officials or missionaries. You could see her face change as she realized that the official record of her people's experiences was being told entirely through the eyes of outsiders who often didn't understand or respect her culture. That was a turning point for me. I realized my job wasn't just to hand over documents and say “this is what we have.” Instead, I needed to help her understand what she was looking at: who wrote these documents, why they were written, and what perspectives might be missing. We talked about those limitations of our collections, and I helped her think about other places she might look for different voices and stories.

I had a similar experience with an African American patron who was researching his family's local history. He was so excited to get started, but as he went through the traditional collections, his excitement turned to frustration. He asked, "Where are we? Where are our stories?" It was heartbreaking, because he was right; his family's experiences were largely invisible in our records. These moments taught me that we can’t just pretend that our collections are neutral or complete. They reflect the historical reality about whose voices were considered important enough to preserve.

When I work with patrons now, I try to be upfront about these gaps. I'll say something like, "Our collection is strong in certain areas, but I want you to know that some communities' experiences are not well represented here. Let's talk about other places we might look."

Language is another area where I have learned to be more thoughtful. Historical documents often contain terms that are outdated or offensive by today's standards. I used to just read them out loud without comment, but I learned that can be really jarring for patrons. Now I prepare them by saying something like, "Just so you know, this document uses language that was common in 1920, but we consider it inappropriate today." It's a small thing but it makes a big difference in how people feel.

I also watch for emotional reactions when people encounter difficult material: documents about slavery, forced relocation, and religious persecution. These aren't just historical artifacts to the people whose families lived through those experiences. I remember when one woman started crying when she found a document describing the conditions her grandmother faced as an immigrant. I learned that the most professional thing you can do is quietly give someone space to process the discovery.

Language barriers can be just as important. I have worked with patrons whose first language isn't English, and I have seen just how intimidating our finding aids can be when you are already struggling with the language. I have learned to slow down, use simpler terms, and check in more often to make sure they're following along. There was one researcher from a community who emphasized oral tradition, and she seemed overwhelmed by our document-heavy approach. Instead of just pushing more papers at her, we talked about how oral histories can complement the written record, and I suggested that she talk with family members and community elders as part of her research process.

It's also important to be honest when our collections lack diverse experiences. Be honest about the limitations, but also be proactive in suggesting alternate sources: maybe another institution has stronger collections in the related subject, or online databases or digital collections that could supplement our holdings.

I want to be really clear that cultural sensitivity doesn't mean you have to avoid difficult subjects or pretend that problematic historical materials don't exist. Historical documents contain offensive language, describe terrible events, or reflect viewpoints that we find deeply troubling today. That's part of history, and we can't change it by avoiding it. But what we can do is handle these materials thoughtfully. When you're working with a patron, and you come across something potentially upsetting, acknowledge it directly. You might say something like, "I want to let you know this collection contains language and viewpoints

that many people find offensive today. These documents reflect the attitudes of a particular time, but that does not make them any less difficult to read." This gives them a chance to prepare emotionally and lets them know that you are aware of the challenges they might encounter.

Sometimes patrons have very strong reactions to what they find. They might be upset, angry, or deeply moved by what they are reading. That's completely normal and understandable. Your job isn't to fix their emotional response or minimize their feelings. Your job is to listen respectfully, provide whatever assistance you can within your role, and help them continue their research if they want to. But the most important thing is to be genuine in your interactions. People can tell if you are not being authentic. If you're not sure how to handle a situation, it's okay to say something like, "I can see this material is really affecting you. Would it be helpful to take a break, or to talk about what you're finding?" Sometimes simply acknowledging how difficult the history or the research is can be incredibly supportive.

Slide Fifteen:

Good customer service in archives is really about being a good human being. Yes, we have policies and procedures, and yes, they matter, but at the end of the day we're helping real people with real needs. Customer service in archives is different from retail or hospitality, because we're not just providing a service. We're teaching, counseling and problem-solving, all in one. When someone comes in looking for information about their grandfather's military service, they may find something they weren't expecting, and we need to be ready for those emotional moments.

Listening is huge. I mean really listening, not just waiting for your turn to talk. A patron will tell you what they want, but listen for what they're really asking and what lies beneath it. A genealogist might not actually need the records they asked for, or a student researching local business history might get more from oral histories than from corporate documents.

Patience is probably the hardest skill to maintain, especially when you're busy and someone asks the same question for the third time. For many people, this is their first time in an archive, and what seems obvious to us is completely foreign to them. Empathy matters more than you might think. Historical research can be emotionally intense. People discover hidden family secrets, confront difficult feelings about the past, or feel overwhelmed by the complexity of research questions. Sometimes the best thing you can do is just acknowledge their feelings and help them process what they're learning. The education side of our customer service is really important. We don't just find materials for people; we teach them how to be better researchers by showing them how to evaluate

resources, explaining why context matters, and helping them understand what they're looking at. This pays off because researchers become more independent and advocates for archives.

Slide Sixteen:

Let's talk about the hard stuff. It's going to happen: you'll have patrons who are frustrated, demanding, or just having a really bad day, and they take it out on you even though you are trying your best to help them. Many difficult situations start with unmet expectations. Someone wants to find something that doesn't exist, or they expect the process to be faster than it actually is, or perhaps they misunderstood our policies. The key is to address the expectation problem, not just the complaint.

Slide Seventeen:

Handling challenging situations is really an art form, one we have developed over time. You'd be surprised how often we encounter them. Researchers walk in expecting immediate access to materials that are fragile, restricted, or simply stored elsewhere. Or someone has come across the country and has only one day in our archives. Of course I understand their urgency, but we still have to explain that certain documents need special handling or advance notice. It’s tough when someone’s entire research trip hinges on something that we cannot produce on the spot.

Technology frustrations are also incredibly common. Maybe a patron working on genealogy research who throws up her hands when her database search doesn't work the way she expected, or when the microfilm reader starts acting up. Sometimes people just need to vent about how things used to be simpler. A little empathy goes a long way.

Policy disagreements can get heated, especially around photographing materials or accessing sensitive records. Patrons don't always understand why we have restrictions, and some feel we're deliberately making their research harder. We have had to get good at explaining the why behind our rules without sounding defensive.

And then there are the emotional moments that can catch you off guard. Someone researching their family's immigration story might break down when they find a document that changes everything they thought they knew. Others get overwhelmed when they're digging into painful historical events. In each moment, remember that we're not just handling papers and files; we're dealing with people's connections to the past. Staying helpful and professional while learning to navigate tricky encounters is something we're always working on.

Slide Eighteen:

When someone gets upset, stay calm, and focus on what you can do, rather than what you can't. Instead of saying "We don't have that," try "Here's what we do have that might help with your research." Instead of saying "that's against our policy," try explaining a policy, and see if there's another way to meet their needs. Essentially, listening to their concerns and validating their frustrations while remaining professional is the goal. However, know when you need to get help. If someone is making unreasonable demands or harassing you, you don't have to handle every situation by yourself. Never put yourself in an unsafe position.

Slide Nineteen:

The best patron relationships develop over time. The graduate student panicking about their thesis might become a regular researcher who brings other students with them. The genealogist who started with one question about their family might become a volunteer who helps other researchers.

Follow up when you can. If you promise to look into something, actually do it. If you hear about a new acquisition that matches someone's interests, drop them a note These small gestures build trust and loyalty. Be genuinely interested in their research: ask questions, celebrate their discoveries, and remember what they're working on. It's not only good customer service; it makes your job more interesting, too.

Slide Twenty:

So how do we put all this into practice? It's not enough to learn the skills once. We need regular practice, training, and honest feedback. Cross-training is essential because patrons don't care who is assigned to what; they need help, so everyone should know the basics of every position, even if they specialize in certain areas. Professional organizations like the Society of American Archivists offer training standards and networking opportunities that help us keep up with best practices. The SAA Core Values Statement and Code of Ethics remind us to be respectful, honest, transparent, and equitable in all of our professional relationships. That's not just nice language; it's a road map for how we interact with patrons each and every day. Conferences and workshops connect us to the broader profession and expose us to new ideas, and if you can't travel, many organizations offer virtual options. We also share professional literature, online forums, and networks with colleagues at other institutions. It helps us learn from each other's experiences and keeps us from reinventing the wheel.

We also need to create comprehensive written policies that cover all these areas, clear enough that staff and visitors can easily understand them. For patron registration and

orientation, we should establish clear procedures for welcoming newcomers and gathering the information we need. This means deciding what identification we require, how we introduce people to the rules for handling collections, and what basic rules we need to communicate. A good orientation policy helps visitors feel comfortable from their very first visit.

Our material access and handling policies have to strike the right balance between preservation and accessibility. We have to spell out which materials patrons can access directly, what needs supervision, and how we handle materials. Clear policies protect our collections and help patrons understand why certain precautions matter. It's not about being difficult; it's about ensuring these materials survive for future researchers.

Technology use and support policies should address both our equipment and patrons' own devices. That includes everything from reservation systems for computers and scanners to rules about personal laptops and camera use. We also need to define what level of technical support we can realistically offer. Are we helping with everything, or do we draw the line somewhere? Being upfront about this helps manage expectations.

Accessibility accommodation policies ensure we truly serve everyone who walks through our doors. They go beyond physical access to include things like extra research time for people with disabilities, alternate formats for finding aids, or modified handling procedures when needed. These policies keep the archives welcoming and usable for all researchers. And finally, our customer service standards should capture the helpful atmosphere we want to maintain: response times for inquiries, how we handle complaints, and the general tone of all our interactions. Good service standards help ensure every patron gets the same experience, regardless of which staff member they work with. Together, these policies give staff a consistent foundation, and patrons know what to expect.

Slide Twenty-One:

Quality assurance isn't just about following procedures; it's about staying connected with the people we serve. Check in with patrons and ask how things are going and if they are finding everything that they need. A simple "Hey, how are you doing?" can reveal that someone has been struggling silently for twenty minutes. We also rely on each other as a team. During breaks, we share stories about what worked well and what didn't. Maybe someone discovered a new way to explain how our catalog system works, or we noticed that patrons keep getting stuck on the same step in the research process. These conversations help us learn from each other's experiences and catch things we might miss on our own.

What seems easy to us can be completely overwhelming to a patron. A database search that takes us thirty seconds can take much longer for someone who isn't familiar with our system, and the microfilm reader we use every day without thinking may be something a patron has never encountered before. When we regularly check in with patrons and with our colleagues, we catch these moments before they become roadblocks.

Staying up to date on emergency procedures means being ready for whatever comes up in the archives. When you're working with researchers day in and day out, you never know what might happen. Medical emergencies in research spaces are rare but do happen. We need to know what to do if a patron faints, has an allergic reaction, or if a researcher falls. Basic first aid, and knowing when to call for help, can make all the difference in those critical first moments.

Technology failures happen too. Imagine a patron who has traveled a long way to access a rare digital collection for their dissertation, and our system crashes or the scanner goes down. We need quick solutions so their effort to get here isn't wasted. We also encounter challenging interpersonal situations that require careful handling. Sometimes patrons become frustrated over access restrictions, or someone may be disruptive to other researchers. Occasionally we deal with individuals who make other visitors uncomfortable. Clear protocols tell us how to handle these situations while keeping everyone safe and protecting the research environment our archives are known for.

And of course we can't forget building emergencies: fires, severe weather, power outages, or other events that put people and historical materials at risk. We need solid evacuation plans and procedures that protect both you and our collections. After all, many of these documents are unique. They exist nowhere else in the world.

Slide Twenty-Two:

At the end of the day, this job is about people. Yes, we care about preserving materials and maintaining professional standards, but our real purpose is helping people connect with history in meaningful ways. Every positive interaction we have, makes someone more likely to value archives and historical research. Every time a researcher discovers something amazing, we are creating an advocate for our profession. Every time we make someone feel welcome and supported, we build stronger communities. This work matters. Whether it's someone discovering new information about their ancestors, a student locating primary sources for the first time, or a researcher finishing their project for a local community group, we make that possible.

There will be frustrating days when the technology doesn't cooperate or when we just can't find what someone desperately needs. But we also have those magical moments when

everything comes together, and we know we've made a real difference in someone's research journey. Thank you for listening today, for caring about doing this work well, and for your part in serving our community. Together, we can ensure that everyone who comes through our doors has the best possible experience exploring the amazing materials we have the privilege to steward.